

HEAVY WEIGHT Chirag Paswan with supporters at a 'Bahujan Bhim Sankalp Samagam' rally in Rajgir

THE NATION | **BIHAR**

CHIRAG'S POWER PLAY

In Bihar's liminal political spaces—between the BJP's leadership deficit and the JD(U)'s ebbing influence—Chirag Paswan sees a fault line ripe for exploitation

By **AMITABH SRIVASTAVA**

ON

ON JULY 26, UNION MINISTER CHIRAG PASWAN WAS IN GAYA to address a public gathering when he lashed out at the Nitish Kumar-led NDA regime in Bihar. "I am sorry I have to support this government," he told the media when asked about the ambulance rape incident that had rocked the town—and made national headlines—two days earlier. "Murders, kidnappings, rape... yet the state machinery prostrates itself before criminals." Though he refrained from naming the chief minister, there was no mistaking who his salvo was aimed at—the home department works under Nitish.

Insiders acknowledge that Chirag's withering critique was no knee-jerk reaction, nor a bargaining ploy for more seats in alliance negotiations. With the Bihar as-